

BULLETIN

Number Thirty-two
October, 1970

Dr. Sidney Cohen, one-time LSD enthusiast turned skeptic, once said to Tim Leary in a debate: "I'll give you my brain when I die, if you'll leave yours to an institute of my designation." It is not known what Sid thought Tim might want with Sid's brain, but what he wanted to do with Tim's was to have it examined for possible organic damage. The idea that repeated LSD use might harm the brain is one than anti-psychedelic spokesmen and journalists have often propagated and many users have worried about it.

It was Dr. Cohen who, despite the temporary inaccessibility of Timothy Leary's head, eventually did the first systematic study testing for organic brain damage in LSD users. The report of this study by Sidney Cohen and Allen Edwards was read before the American Medical Association in June 1968.

Cohen selected thirty subjects who had each taken LSD 50 or more times. Most had used a variety of other drugs as well. They were given a series of tests called the "Halstead-Reitan neuropsychological test battery" which, according to the authors of this study, "is probably the best validated behavioral test for detecting and localizing brain damage." It is composed of sub-tests of concept formation, tactual performance, speech perception, rhythm perception, finger tapping and trail making. Cohen also gave a non-verbal intelligence test. A control group, matched with the LSD group for race, age, sex, years of education and socio-economic background, was given the same tests.

The two groups did not differ significantly on most tests; however the LSD group scored significantly lower than the controls on a visual spatial orientation test and on one that involved following a map. Both were related to visual orientation. Cohen adds that the scores on the intelligence test were inversely related to the number of LSD ingestions, although the average intelligence of the group as a whole was high, and did not differ from the average intelligence of the control group. Cohen concludes, "There is no evidence of a generalized psychoneurological dysfunction attributable to taking LSD at least 50 times. Still, evidence exists that visual spatial orientation is impaired."

In 1969 (*Archives of Gen. Psychiatry, Vol 21*) William McGlothlin performed a similar study, the purpose of which was, in part, to see whether Cohen's findings would be replicated. He took sixteen subjects who had taken LSD 20 or more times, and a control group matched for sex and the means of age and education and gave them several of the same tests Cohen used, including the two on which Cohen's subjects showed a difference between users and non-users, plus several new tests also designed to see whether subjects had a deficit in the area of visual spatial orientation, and an intelligence test.

The LSD users did significantly worse than the controls on only one of these tests - a test of ability to discern abstract principles. This test was also part of Cohen's study, but in that study there was no difference between the two groups. McGlothlin's LSD subjects did not do significantly worse than his controls on the spatial orientation and visual tests. Like

PIC BULLETIN THE 6 RULES OF PHANEROTHYME: Do not take it more than
is issued every once in 3 months. Take it at least once a year.
two months by Lisa Take it reverently. Plan the setting and group
Bieberman, 144 St. Botolph carefully. Ask God's guidance before, dur-
St, 2B, Boston MA 02115. Send ing and after. If phanerothyme gives
STAMPED, ADDRESSED ENVELOPES for you a clear leading, carry it out -
future issues. No subscriptions sold. but be sure it's clear.

worse than his controls on the spatial orientation and visual tests. Like Cohen, McGlothlin found no difference in intelligence between LSD users and controls; unlike Cohen, McGlothlin found no particular relationship between intelligence test scores and number of LSD ingestions.

In other words, the impairment suggested by the Cohen study was not replicated by the McGlothlin study and the impairment suggested by the McGlothlin study is not confirmed by the Cohen study, which makes it seem likely that in both cases the findings were due to chance. This is not too surprising, because when you give a large number of tests, the probability of getting a statistically significant result on one of them by accident is greatly increased.

Thus there is no evidence to date connecting LSD use with generalized brain damage or impairment comparable to that found in persons with proven brain lesions. Evidence for a lesser degree of impairment is inconsistent. These tests were done on heavy users, most of whom had taken much more LSD than I or other psychedelic researchers would advise. So that seems to be the state of the question, and if more evidence arises, I'll report on it.

* * * * *

Dear Lisa,

I have recently received your booklets, "Session Games People Play" and "Phanerothyme," as well as your article "What God Is Doing With Drugs." ...and find so much in them that confirms my own feelings and experience, that I wanted to write to you.

As a clinical instructor in a School of Social Work working with students and teen-age clients in the drug dependency field, I took LSD a year ago to see what kids were experiencing and to gain some additional understanding of the problem of abuse of "acid."

I had done a good deal of reading..., had talked with many kids about their experiences, and, in working with "encounter" groups of kids, had a hunch that there existed some relationship between the "peak experiences" achieved in these groups and the psychedelic experience. But I had to know for myself, and I decided that the best way was to "turn on" in as similar a way as the kids I was working with, which meant use of a "street" drug, bombardment with the stimuli of lights, motion and stereo music, etc. ... I now realize that this was a very abusive way to use the drug, even though the experience was a "good" one.

...That I had a phanerothymic experience at all was quite remarkable and I consider myself fortunate, since that aspect of it was far, far more meaningful than all of the others that I have come to refer to as "psychological fireworks," since it was here that I gained what I have been able to use most in my personal life and in my relationships with clients and students. All the rest was mere entertainment.

The ideas that came to me were basically these:

1. That I had been given an intense look at myself from within, and that I had nothing to fear from within. (I am often assailed by self-doubt and have found this revelation most comforting in giving me renewed confidence in my own abilities);

2. That there is a cosmic unity - that all aspects of the universe (including myself and my fellow man) interact in an integrated way towards ultimate good;

3. That while people that I loved and with whom I worked (my wife, my children, my students, my friends and my clients) needed me, I very much needed them, and I had forgotten this. I later discussed this in a very close encounter with my wife and she confirmed that I appeared to her so self-sufficient that there was no way in which I appeared to need her. I

have since been trying very hard to devote more of myself to my wife and family, whom I do love and need very much, although I continue to slip badly in this regard.

One boy who was a client and who had taken LSD some 50 or 60 times while he was 14 and 15 and who at that time was taking it sometimes as often as 3 times a week, as well as heroin and speed occasionally, came vividly to my mind. I had come to care for him very much and while I was aware that he needed me, I had lost sight of the awareness that I needed him. That both client and therapist have needs and resources that they each put into their relationship is often lost sight of and results in the therapist thinking and behaving as a superior being. I was able to share my LSD experience with this boy, and he began to see that his continually being "stoned" was preventing him from experiencing some of these existential things that he had been searching for in his life. He has now put between 3 and 6 months between his LSD trips and has been finding more and more value in his life between. Life itself has become important to him and much more than merely a period of depressed boredom between trips.

4. That there is a God, that He is love, and that He is everywhere was revealed to me with renewed freshness and confirmation, even though I considered myself a Christian and have seen Christ as the Model for my own life for a long time. The knowledge that God is within me was especially vivid and the fact that I had an awesome responsibility to use my life to spread God's love in everything that I did was especially clear. I continue to avoid this responsibility all too often.

Like you, I have found these revelations from my LSD experience very much related to my Christian faith and serving to confirm me in that faith (although I am so often a poor example of that faith!) Like you, also, I found a child-like simplicity in what I learned.

My vocation is that of social work and my continuing goal that of making my profession a more humane and humanizing one, as a teacher of social work students and as a practitioner. My specific area of concern continues to be that of the problems that result from drug abuse. I led a research group of students in a study of family, peer, and school factors motivating the abuse of drugs and presented a brief from that study to our Federal Commission of Inquiry into the Non-Medical Use of Drugs (Ledain Commission). The Commission has just published its interim report and will greatly influence the course of drug legislation in Canada.*

My own experience and your booklets... have led me to think about doing some research into these phanerothymic aspects of LSD and related drugs. It seems to me that if we could in some way contribute to public knowledge of this side of drug use through research, this would contribute not only to the eventual availability of phanerothyme for religious purposes but also for therapeutic purposes. ...I plan to go on leave for doctoral study next Sept. so I would have the opportunity to do a major research project. ...

Peace,
Bob Chandler

(I question whether research in this area can go further than what Walter Pahnke and Walter Clark have already effectively established, showing that

*The Interim Report published last May did not go as far as many had hoped, in recommending liberalization of Canada's drug laws, but it did propose elimination prison for drug possession, making this punishable by not more than a \$100 fine. The Commission's study will continue during the coming year and there is some hope that it may advocate removal of the crime of possession and legalization of cannabis possession and sale. A copy of the report can be obtained from: Commission of Inquiry into the Non-Medical Use of Drugs, Berger Building, 100 Metcalfe St., Ottawa, Ontario, Canada.

psychedelic drugs often do give rise to religious experiences. Where phanerothymists differ from their opponents is over the question of the validity of such experiences, and this is a theological problem not ultimately answerable by science. Was Bob Chandler right when he saw that God is Love, or was he deluded? Is it true, as phanerothyme revealed to the young man whose letter appears below, that killing is wrong? What kind of research will ever answer these questions? Many encounters have led me to believe that the antipathy toward drug use felt by many otherwise liberal people lies at another level than the rational.)

* * * * *

Dear Miss Bieberman,

OK. So I'm a Christian; I prayed as I dropped the tab, and my semi-annual freakout became instead a very pleasurable experience... What does it mean? Your Bulletins speak about acid, which I already know about: What About Jesus? What do all the weird things he says (usually contradicted by his actions) mean? When I was on phanerothyme, it seemed very clear to me that all men are by nature bastards, that there is a God (and what a ridiculous thing it is to believe that there might not be one), that Jesus lived the perfect life, and that by believing in him any man might gain eternal life. The beauty, clarity, and simplicity of the thoughts are of course not describable. But now, my back itches, and I wonder what those thoughts have to do with anything.

It seemed to me, on acid, that one simple, absolute, obvious rule of life was Thou Shalt Not Kill. It was only after coming down that I realized that that made me a PACifist! Which is certainly not anything I ever intended to be. ~~What about the Jew~~ ^{in world war two?} Yet killing still seems so absurd. I think a lot about such things. I'm eighteen come September. I'll bet, though, that America could devise means of waging war without killing anybody (or at least maintain minimum deaths). Hell, we don't even have our cops use non-lethal guns.

One more thing: I keep getting uncomfortable over pain. Why is pain?

Sincerely,

* * * * *

"I have heard client after client after client state that he reached his Conscientious Objector position as a result of psychedelic drug experiences."

a draft-counselor friend

* * * * *

The 7th Annual Meeting of the Church of the Awakening will be held at the home of John and Maxine Brill, 10685 Esterina Way, Culver City, Calif. at 2:30 pm, November 8, 1970. Interested persons are invited whether members or not. The C of A's petition to the Bureau of Narcotics and Dangerous Drugs for recognition of their legal right to the sacramental use of peyote, denied seven months after the July, 1969, hearing, is being appealed. The appeal court decision is not expected for at least six months.

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Literature available from PIC:

SESSION GAMES PEOPLE PLAY - A Manual for the Use of LSD. \$1.

PHANEROTHYME - A Western Approach to the Religious Use of Psychochemicals. 75¢.

"What God Is Doing with Drugs" (talk given at Wilmington College, Ohio). 25

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